otherwise quiet night in the capital was taking a serious turn with every senior bureaucrat appearing to be baffled. The news of the assassination was that unexpected.

Anirudhya had a quick coffee at Triveni in Mandi House with the head of IB's Delhi unit and got a basic story in place to start with: The Director of CBI, Vijay Karan, would be leaving for Madras the next morning in a special aircraft, the interim Prime Minister of the country, Chandra Shekhar, had rushed back from Bhubaneswar and held a series of closed-door meetings with Cabinet Secretary Naresh Chandra, Home Secretary R.K. Bhargava, Research & Analysis Wing (R&AW) chief G.S. Bajpai, Director of IB M.K. Narayanan, Director of CBI Raja Vijay Karan, the defence secretary and the three service chiefs (of the navy, army and air force) and the director of the Military Intelligence (MI). He also learnt that thirty Black Cat commandos of the National Security Guard (NSG) were on standby at the airport, ready to leave for Madras at any time.

The Prime Minister, in consultation with CBI Director Vijay Karan and Additional Director S.K. Datta, had set up a Special Investigation Team (SIT). The inspector general (IG) of the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) D.R. Kaarthikeyan was chosen to head the team. He said he had received a call from Datta, who said intelligence agencies such as the R&AW, MI, the Joint Intelligence Committee (JIC) and IB had no clue about the identity of the assassin. Unlike the assassinations of Mahatma Gandhi and Indira Gandhi, where the assassins were witnessed committing the crime and caught immediately, the assassins of Rajiv Gandhi had vanished into thin air. Not a single name had come up. It reminded them of US President John F. Kennedy's assassination. Datta reportedly told Kaarthikeyan that he was the best for the job. Kaarthikeyan, a 1964-batch IPS officer, had done law before clearing the UPSC. He was well connected, had strong managerial skills and had varied experiences, including on diplomatic missions and non-police organizations. And, more importantly, he could handle political pressure. But why would someone from the CRPF be brought in when the CBI had more than a dozen sleuths with enviable track records in investigating big cases? The idea, Anirudhya